

 **Media Studies 200: Intro to Media Studies**
 Intended for 60 undergraduate students
 Fall 2026 at UVic | CRN: 12185 | Req: AWR
 M and Th, 1-2:20pm | COR B108 | 1.5 units
 Taught by [Jentery Sayers](#) (he | him) | jentery@uvic.ca
 Office hours: Th, 2:30-3:30pm in CLE D331
 Teaching assistant (marking): Tatiana Popova (she | her)
 View this [document online](#)

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Territory Acknowledgement

We acknowledge and respect the Ləkʷəŋən (Songhees and Xʷsepsəm / Esquimalt) Peoples on whose territory the university stands, and the Ləkʷəŋən and W̱SÁNEĆ Peoples whose historical relationships with the land continue to this day.

In [this video](#), Yux'wey'lupton, Dr. Clarence "Butch" Dick of the Songhees Nation, welcomes visitors to the traditional lands of the Ləkʷəŋən (Songhees and Xʷsepsəm / Esquimalt) and W̱SÁNEĆ Peoples in Ləkʷəŋən and English. This acknowledgement was developed through UVic's continued dialogue and relationships with the local Nations, in recognition of their presence and governance structure in these territories.

Description

This course "surveys the cultural and material roles media play around the world in the 21st century. Emphasis on building a common vocabulary for studying media as well as understanding how audio, images, video, and text mediate people's relation to culture." For more information, see "[MDIA200 - Media in the 21st Century](#)" in UVic's academic calendar.

The course counts toward UVic's new major, minor, general, and certificate in [Media Studies](#).

Goals

I designed this course for you to:

- Build a vocabulary for understanding media. This means we'll identify the particulars of audio, images, text, video, and interfaces as they pertain to content creation and media analysis.
- Practice techniques for engaging media. This means we'll experiment with different critical approaches to media in the 21st century.
- Account for context and culture in the analysis of media across the globe. This means we'll consider how, where, when, by whom, for whom, and under what assumptions media are made, interpreted, circulated, and preserved.
- Respond directly to classroom activities and lectures about media. This means you'll complete fourteen exit tickets and three worksheets to demonstrate and apply what you're learning.
- Reflect on your learning and communicate its applications to the study and production of media today. This reflection will assume the form of a portfolio, which will be your final project in this course.

I will assume you've no experience in Media Studies, and I will focus on critical approaches to media as they apply to media practice. I will not teach film or music. For that, I recommend [Film Studies](#) and the [School of Music](#). I also won't teach professional communication or journalism. For that, I recommend [Professional Communication](#) and [Professional Writing](#), respectively.

About Us

My name is Jentery Sayers (he/him). I skip a syllable and say it in two: "JEN-tree." You can call me Jentery, Doctor Sayers, or Professor Sayers.

I spend 9.76% of the day looking for my glasses, and I enjoy writing about games and media. I grew up in Richmond, Virginia and went to Virginia Commonwealth University for my BA and BS degrees. Then I moved to Seattle, where I received an MA and PhD in English from the University of Washington. I relocated to Victoria the summer I received my PhD, and I currently direct UVic's Media Studies program. I like to play TTRPGs, drums, guitar, and basketball in my spare time. I also do my best to maintain a [portfolio](#) of my work.

You can email me at jentery@uvic.ca or find me in Clearihue D331. My office hours are Thursday, 2:30-3:30pm, or by appointment, in CLE D331. I respond to emails Monday through Friday, 9am - 5pm, excluding holidays.

Hi! I'm Tatiana (she/her), your TA for the term. I'll be reviewing your exit tickets and grading them. You can reach me at tpopova@uvic.ca.

I'm a PhD candidate in the interdisciplinary program in Pacific and Asian Studies and Sociology, where my research focuses on immigration in Japan, particularly how

immigration policies shape the lives and experiences of different groups of migrant workers. When I'm not working or writing my dissertation, I'm usually spending time with my family and my very energetic 3-year-old, pretending I have time for video games, or convincing myself that going for a run is a good idea.

Materials

You do *not* need to purchase a textbook or any primary sources for this course, but you will need access to a computer, the internet (including [Brightspace](#)), a camera, and a microphone.

Handouts: I produce my own handouts for this course and circulate them as PDFs in Brightspace. They include concise overviews of key themes and terms to help you prepare for upcoming class sessions. You can think of them as an alternative to a Media Studies textbook.

Slide decks: I create HTML slide decks for most class sessions and link to them in Brightspace immediately before class begins. This way, you can access my slides during and after class.

Source materials: My slide decks and handouts contain source materials or links to them. We'll discuss these sources in class to apply what you're learning from the weekly handouts. Examples of primary sources we'll study this term include the browser game, *Hair Nah* (2017), by Momo Pixel; the comic, "[Translated, From the Japanese](#)" (2015), by Adrian Tomine; and the stop-motion animation, *Biidaaban (The Dawn Comes)* (2018), by Amanda Strong, Leanne Betasamosake Simpson, and Bracken Hanuse Corlett.

Content warnings: I'll include content warnings for materials before I share or screen them in class.

Recordings: I do not plan to record our class sessions; however, you are welcome to record audio for private access, study, and note-taking.

Brightspace: I'll use the course Brightspace to:

- Circulate a class announcement each week to help you plan for what's next,
- Share weekly handouts, my slides, and any source materials we study in class,
- Point you to resources available online,
- Accept all of your assignments except the exit tickets (please don't submit anything to me by email), and
- Mark those assignments and provide feedback on them.

Assignments

There are no exams, quizzes, presentations, or group projects in this course.

I am asking you to complete five assignments this term.

- **Exit tickets:** 10% of your final grade (14 of them, each due by the end of class on the day prompted)
- **Worksheet 1:** 20% of your final grade (due by Monday, October 5th)
- **Worksheet 2:** 20% of your final grade (due by Monday, October 26th)
- **Worksheet 3:** 25% of your final grade (due by Monday, November 30th)
- **Portfolio:** 25% of your final grade (due by Monday, December 14th)

Exit tickets (14 of them): At the end of 19 different class sessions, I will ask you to use a notecard (which I will provide) to respond to a prompt that will ask you to share what you're learning from class sessions, what you hope to learn, and/or what questions you have. You will submit your responses on the notecard by the end of class. You should submit a total of 14 exit tickets (meaning you don't need to submit one at the end of every class), and we will track your submissions in Brightspace. See the schedule below for sessions *without* an exit ticket.

Worksheets (3 of them): The worksheets will ask you to apply what you're learning in class through a combination of media (audio, images, text, and video), and I will encourage you to use class time to take notes and draft your responses to them. I will circulate each worksheet well before it's due, and I'll review each prompt in class to ensure it's clear. The worksheets and their grading rubrics are posted online (see links above). You should download them, complete them in your word processor of choice (e.g., Word, Docs, Pages), and submit them via Brightspace.

Portfolio (1 of them): You'll conclude MDIA 200 by producing a portfolio that documents what you learned in this course, reflects on that learning, and communicates its significance to someone in particular (e.g., a professor, student, friend, or family member).

Brightspace: Please use Brightspace to submit your worksheets and portfolio. You do not need to purchase any software to use Brightspace, but you will need your UVic NetLink ID, access to the internet, and a computer. I cannot accept assignments (including exit tickets) by email.

Feedback: I will provide brief and focused feedback on worksheets according to their grading rubrics. Please email me or schedule an appointment (F2F or Zoom) to discuss the feedback. Again, I respond to emails Monday through Friday, 9am - 5pm, excluding holidays. Thanks in advance for your patience.

Workload

The most important thing to know about this course is that *I'll opt for care in every instance*. If the workload becomes too much or we're juggling more than we should, then we'll cut material. I planned for the maximum in advance, under the assumption we won't get to everything. And that's totally fine.

I suggest dedicating *3 to 5 hours* to MDIA 200 each week in addition to our weekly meetings on Monday and Thursday. Of course, 3 to 5 hours per week is only a guideline. You may find that you need more or less time depending on the activity, your preferences, and your familiarity with the materials and work involved.

Schedule

Here's the schedule for the term. It's subject to change. I will use a Brightspace announcement to notify you at least two weeks in advance of those changes, and I will never use schedule changes to increase your workload (e.g., add an assignment or reading).

All materials (including the handouts) for this course are available via Brightspace. Please study them before the date they're assigned. This way, we can make the most of our time together in class.

All meetings are scheduled to occur in person (face-to-face). I will assume you are attending each class meeting. If you are unable to attend, then please email me in advance and coordinate with a peer to get notes and the like from the session(s) you'll miss. My slides for each session will be available in Brightspace.

You are welcome to record audio of the following sessions for private access, study, and note-taking.

Th Sept. 10: Hello!

We'll introduce ourselves, and I'll provide an overview of the course.

After class, please read:

1. The course outline, including the schedule and policies, and
2. The "Content Industry" handout.

no exit ticket today

Please email me if you're on the waitlist for this course and have questions or concerns.

MODULE 1: Communication (four sessions)

This module begins on Monday, Sept. 14th and ends on Thursday, Sept. 24th.

M Sept. 14: Acts and Senses of Communication

Before class, please read the following handouts:

1. "Acts of Communication" and
2. "Senses of Communication."

no exit ticket today

Please email me if you have any trouble accessing my slide decks in Brightspace.

Th Sept. 17: Means and Levels of Communication

Before class, please read the following handouts:

1. "Means of Communication" and
2. "Levels of Communication."

Exit tickets begin today and end on Monday, November 30th.

Please email me if you have any questions or concerns about Worksheet 1 or the exit tickets.

M Sept. 21: Forms and Models of Communication

Before class, please read the following handouts:

1. "Forms of Communication" and
2. "Models of Communication."

September 22nd is the last day for a 100% reduction of tuition fees for standard first-term courses.

Th Sept. 24: Noise and Miscommunication

Before class, please read the "Noise and Miscommunication" handout.

Today is the last session covered by Worksheet 1, which is due by Monday, October 5th.

MODULE 2: Media (six sessions)

This module begins on Monday, September 28th and ends on Monday, October 19th.

M Sept. 28: Understanding Media

Before class, please read the following handouts:

1. "Understanding Media" and
2. "Paradigms of Media."

September 30th is National Day for Truth and Reconciliation. The University is closed.

September 30th is the last day to pay first-term fees without penalty.

Th Oct. 1: Images

Before class, please read the following handouts:

1. "Images" and
2. "Comics."

M Oct. 5: Text

Before class, please read the “Text” handout.

Worksheet 1 is due today.

Th Oct. 8: Audio

Before class, please read the “Audio” handout.

Please email me if you have any questions or concerns about Worksheet 2.

M Oct. 12: No Class

October 12th is Thanksgiving. The University is closed.

October 13th is the last day for a 50% reduction of tuition fees for standard courses.

no exit ticket today

Th Oct. 15: Video

Before class, please read the “Video” handout.

M Oct. 19: Interfaces

Before class, please read the “Interfaces” handout.

Please email me if you have any questions or concerns about the feedback I provided on Worksheet 1.

Today is the last session covered by Worksheet 2, which is due by Monday, October 26th.

MODULE 3: Approaches (eleven sessions)

This module begins on Thursday, October 22nd and ends on Thursday, December 3rd.

Th Oct. 22: Media Effects

Before class, please read the “Media Effects” handout.

M Oct. 26: Ownership Effects

Before class, please read the “Ownership Effects” handout.

Worksheet 2 is due today.

Th Oct. 29: Communities and Cultures

Before class, please read the “Culture” handout.

October 31st is the last day to withdraw from first-term courses without penalty of failure.

M Nov. 2: Media Aesthetics

Before class, please read the “Media Aesthetics” handout.

Please email me if you have any questions or concerns about Worksheet 3.

Th Nov. 5: Meaning and Semiotics

Before class, please read the “Meaning and Semiotics” handout.

M Nov. 9: Reading Break

No class today. Enjoy your break!

no exit ticket today

Th Nov. 12: Conferences (no class)

I will hold optional student conferences. Please contact me to schedule an appointment if you would like to discuss your work in this course. I’m happy to chat!

no exit ticket today

M Nov. 16: Rhetoric and Persuasion

Before class, please read the “Rhetoric and Persuasion” handout.

Please email me if you have any questions or concerns about the feedback I provided on Worksheet 2.

Th Nov. 19: Representation and Intersectionality

Before class, please read the “Representation” handout.

M Nov. 23: Narrative and Genre

Before class, please read the “Narrative” handout.

Please email me if you have any questions or concerns about the Portfolio.

Th Nov. 26: Fandom

Before class, please read the “Fandom” handout.

Today is the last session covered by Worksheet 3, which is due by Monday, November 30th.

M Nov. 30: Preservation

Before class, please read the “Preservation” handout.

Worksheet 3 is due today.

Th Dec. 3: Before You Make a Thing

Before class, please read the “Before You Make a Thing” handout.

no exit ticket today

M Dec. 7: Last Session!

We’ll wrap up the class, discuss what you learned, and reflect on what worked and what could be improved.

no exit ticket today

Please email me if you have any questions or concerns about the feedback I provided on Worksheet 3.

December 7th is National Day of Remembrance and Action on Violence Against Women. Classes and exams are cancelled from 11:30am - 12:30pm.

M Dec. 14: Portfolio

Please submit your portfolio today. I hope you’ve a wonderful winter break.

Resources

Here are some resources for the course and your studies at UVic.

UVic Learn Anywhere

[UVic Learn Anywhere](#) is where you can find articles, tip sheets, and video tutorials to develop the learning skills you need for academic success at UVic.

UVic Libraries

Everyone at the [University of Victoria Libraries](#) is committed to the success of UVic’s students and faculty. The library’s foundational role in acquiring and preserving research resources is critical in the complex digital environment of 21st-century scholarship. Their expert staff are increasingly working within disciplines, across disciplines, and beyond traditional boundaries, as they navigate this exciting landscape with students, faculty, and researchers. They welcome the wider public into their physical spaces and actively seek partnerships with local and regional organizations to support and enhance the rich arts, culture, and learning opportunities in UVic’s communities.

Office of Indigenous Academic and Community Engagement (IACE)

The [Office of Indigenous Academic and Community Engagement](#) serves as a hub for cultural, academic, and community connections. Whether you are a student seeking guidance, a community looking to collaborate, or an individual interested in learning more about Indigenous initiatives at UVic, IACE is here to support you on your journey. They

work closely with Indigenous students, staff, faculty, Elders, and community to create opportunities for meaningful engagement, ensuring that Indigenous perspectives and voices are woven into the fabric of their work.

Academic Skills Centre

The [Academic Skills Centre](#) offers online and in-person one-on-one tutorials, workshops, and more. As a priority, they actively coach students on academic integrity, including preventing accidental plagiarism. Their free services are available to all UVic students. They are here to support students with time management and planning for a successful semester. They also coach students on reading, writing, speaking, understanding academic expectations, and other aspects of academic communication. They can support you in creating academic posters, blogposts, PowerPoint slides, and e-portfolios.

Community-Engaged Learning (CEL)

[Community-Engaged Learning](#) is a rewarding way to apply your studies to real-life projects in the community. This type of learning is a partnership between UVic students, faculty, campus partners, and the community beyond campus. It's a way to gain meaningful hands-on experience that supports and honours the community and strengthens your academic experience.

Academic Concessions and Accommodations

If your academic courses are affected by illness, accident, or family affliction, you may wish to request an [academic concession](#). Are you a student with a learning disability, ADHD, mental health issue, or long-term recurring physical or sensory disability? Do you have chronic health issues? If you do, UVic provides academic accommodations to address barriers to your education.

Student Wellness

Their [team of practitioners](#) offers a variety of services to support students' mental, physical, and spiritual health. You can make a same-day or pre-booked appointment with a counsellor, nurse, physician, or spiritual care provider.

Ombudsperson

The [ombuds office](#) is an independent, impartial, and confidential resource for undergraduate and graduate students and other members of the University of Victoria community. The ombudsperson helps resolve student problems or disputes fairly.

Student Groups

The following advocacy groups may be relevant to your life as a student here at UVic:

- [The Native Students Union](#),
- [The Students of Colour Collective](#),
- [The Society for Students with a Disability \(SSD\)](#),

- [The Gender Empowerment Centre \(GEM\)](#), and
- [UVSS Pride Collective](#).

Policies

Here are the policies for this course alongside several UVic policies. Please let me know if anything is unclear, ignorant, or mistaken. I'll correct it.

Media Studies Major, Minor, General, and Certificate

This course counts toward UVic's [Media Studies major, minor, general, and certificate](#). In fact, it's required for all of them.

Office Hours and Contacting Me

The best way to communicate with me is by email (jentery@uvic.ca) or during office hours, which are Thursday, 2:30-3:30pm, in CLE D331. I can also make an appointment to meet with you in person or via Zoom.

I respond to email between 9am and 5pm, Monday through Friday, excluding holidays.

Assessment and Feedback

You must submit two of the three worksheets as well as the portfolio to pass this course. Failure to complete one or more of these elements will result in a grade of "N" regardless of the cumulative percentage of all other elements of the course. N is a failing grade and factors into GPA as a value of 0.

In accordance with the University's policy on academic concessions, "A student who completes all course requirements is not eligible for an academic concession." Consequently, students can only request deferrals for the completion of required course components and not for non-essential course components.

Grades for this course are not official until they have been approved by the Associate Dean Academic in the Faculty of Humanities.

I will use UVic's [official grading system](#) to produce rubrics to assess your work. I will not post marks publicly or outside my office, and I do not use plagiarism or AI detection software.

All assignments except for the exit tickets should be submitted via Brightspace. I cannot accept the exit tickets, worksheets, or portfolio via email. Each exit ticket is due by the end of class on the day it's prompted.

I will use Brightspace to provide feedback on your work. If you ever want additional feedback, then feel free to ask me. I can provide it in person, via Zoom, or by email.

Throughout the term, I'll request feedback from you on how the course is going. I'll also ask you to complete learning experience surveys at the end of the term.

Late Submissions and Extensions

I've a 24-hour grace period (no questions asked, no email required, and no penalties) for every worksheet in this course. A late penalty of five points per business day will apply after 24 hours. Weekends and holidays do not count as business days.

I cannot accept an exit ticket after the class session it was assigned, I will not accept worksheets more than two weeks after they are due, and I cannot accept the portfolio after 10am on Friday, December 18th.

Please email me if you need an extension for any assignment (before it is due), and we can discuss possibilities on a case-by-case basis.

Attendance and Participation

There is no participation or attendance mark in this course; however, every class session will rely heavily on discussion and interaction. I will assume you are attending each class meeting. If you are unable to attend a particular meeting, then please email me in advance and coordinate with a peer to get notes and the like from the session(s) you'll miss.

You do not need to provide me with documentation for an absence.

Equity, Diversity, and Inclusion (EDI)

I aim to create an inclusive learning environment that attends to difference and honours each of you, including your experiences at the intersections of race, ethnicity, gender, disability, sexuality, religion, power, and class. I want to be a resource for you, and I continue to learn about EDI. If something is said in class (by anyone, including me) that makes you feel uncomfortable, then don't hesitate to talk with me. If you have a name and/or set of pronouns that differ from those that appear in your university records, then let me know, and I'll correct the documents provided to me. If your performance in the class is being impeded by your experiences outside of class, then keep me posted, and we'll make adjustments. I also welcome any suggestions to improve the quality of the course, and I will make available mechanisms for anonymous feedback since you may prefer them.

Information for All Students

This [page](#) contains a list of important UVic policies.

Creating a Respectful, Inclusive, and Productive Learning Environment

UVic is committed to promoting critical academic discourse while providing a respectful and productive learning environment across all modalities of learning and teaching. All members of the university community have the right to experience, and the responsibility to help create, such an environment. In any course, the instructor has the primary responsibility for creating a respectful, inclusive and productive learning environment in a manner consistent with other university policies and regulations. Students who have unresolved questions or concerns about a particular learning environment should bring them to the Dean (since Media Studies is not a department, and I am its director).

Accessibility

UVic commits to addressing and removing barriers that hinder full and equal participation of people with disabilities. UVic's [Accessibility Plan](#) includes guiding principles and existing resources. It summarizes consultations, barriers, and priorities for the next three years to address those barriers.

Equity Action Plan

The [Equity Action Plan](#)'s goals provide UVic with strategic direction to advance equity, diversity, and inclusion, and to create the conditions in which everyone feels a sense of belonging: as connected and respected parts of the university community.

Sexualized Violence Prevention and Response

UVic's [Sexualized Violence Resource Office](#) in Equity and Human Rights (EQHR) offers information on how to start the conversation about consent, where to get support on and off campus, and the options available under UVic's Sexualized Violence Prevention and Response Policy.

Accommodation of Religious Observance

UVic recognizes its obligation to make reasonable accommodation for students whose observance of holy days might conflict with the academic requirements of a course or program. Students are permitted to absent themselves from classes, seminars, or workshops for the purposes of religious or spiritual observance. In the case of compulsory classes or course events, students will normally be required to provide reasonable notice to their instructors of their intended absence from the class or event for reasons of religious or spiritual observance. In consultation with the student, the instructor will determine an appropriate means of accommodation. The instructor may choose to reschedule classes or provide individual assistance. Where a student's participation in a class event is subject to grading, every reasonable effort will be made to allow the student to make up for the missed class through alternative assignments or in subsequent classes. Students who require a rescheduled examination must give reasonable notice to their instructors. If a final exam cannot be rescheduled within the regular exam period, students may request an academic concession.

Student Conduct

UVic is committed to promoting a safe, respectful and supportive learning, living, and working environment. As part of the university community, each student is responsible for their personal conduct as it affects the university community, university activities, and the university's property. [The Office of Student Life](#) works directly with the university community to review and help resolve non-academic student conduct concerns. They administer the university's Resolution of Non-Academic Misconduct Allegations policy and serve as a supportive resource to the university community.

The Tri-Faculty of Humanities, Science, and Social Sciences is committed to developing in students the knowledge, skills and values necessary to become leaders in their chosen

professions and good citizens, both locally and globally. To that end, faculty, staff and students work together to promote professionalism, including personal responsibility, respect, honesty and integrity in all our students, and they should be familiar with the [tri-faculty standards for professional behaviour](#).

Non-Academic Student Conduct

UVic's [Non-Academic Misconduct Allegations policy](#) (AC1300) clarifies what non-academic student misconduct is; details how the university responds to non-academic misconduct allegations; outlines the review and investigation processes; describes possible outcomes and ensures that when misconduct is found to have occurred, any sanctions that are applied are fair and consistent; and, explains how to appeal a decision that has been made under the policy.

Academic Integrity

[Academic integrity](#) requires commitment to the values of honesty, trust, fairness, respect, and responsibility. It is expected that students, faculty members, and staff at the University of Victoria, as members of an intellectual community, will adhere to these ethical values in all activities related to learning, teaching, research, and service. Any action that contravenes this standard, including misrepresentation, falsification, or deception, undermines the intention and worth of scholarly work and violates the fundamental academic rights of members of our community. This policy is designed to ensure that the university's standards are upheld in a fair and transparent fashion.

Students are responsible for the entire content and form of their work. Nothing in this policy is intended to prohibit students from developing their academic skills through the exchange of ideas and the utilization of resources available at the university to support learning (e.g., The Centre for Academic Communication). Students who are in doubt as to what constitutes a violation of academic integrity in a particular instance should consult their course instructor.

Copyright

All course materials, including my slides, handouts, and lectures, are made available for educational purposes and the exclusive use of students in this course. The material is protected under copyright law even if it is not marked as such, and the syllabus is licensed [CC BY-NC 4.0](#). Any further use or distribution of materials to others requires written permission, except under fair dealing or another exception in the Copyright Act.

Generative AI Tools

I do not recommend relying on generative AI tools to respond to assignments in this course. AI-generated responses tend to be generic, and they lack self-reflection, which is crucial to Media Studies. AI results can also be biased and incorrect. It is your responsibility to ensure that the information you use from AI is accurate. You should also pay attention to the privacy of your data. Many AI tools will incorporate and use any content (including copyrighted materials, original work, and personal information) you upload, paste, or share

with them. In short, relying on AI could create more work for you in the end, it tends to hinder or “deskill” the learning process, and it’s ultimately not a “market advantage” in media professions.

All sources, including generative AI tools, must be properly cited. I will consider the failure to cite sources and any use of generative AI tools to be an academic integrity violation. Use of generative AI tools includes the use of any software to generate, complete, manipulate, or revise your work; however, the use of grammar checkers is acceptable.

Language for this policy was drawn from language used at the [University of Washington](#).

Basic Needs

I want you to thrive in this course and everywhere else. Please let me know as early as possible if you have any concerns or if you require any supports to succeed. I’ll do my best to help. If, for instance, you need to cover gaps in care, then please don’t hesitate to bring your children to class meetings. Babies who are nursing are welcome, as I do not want you to choose between feeding your child and continuing your education.

Some material in this outline was informed by the Media Texthack Team’s [Media Studies 101](#) project.

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